



novative. However, you must also encourage them to comply with the newly established product or service process. Then only the innovation that you implemented will result in profitable returns.

When and where to use it

Interestingly, in his book, “The Myths of Innovation,” author Scott Berkun writes, “Competence trumps innovation. If you suck at what you do, being innovative will not help you. Business is driven by providing value to customers. Often, that can be done without innovation; make a good and needed thing, sell it at a good price, and advertise confidently. If you need innovations to achieve those three things, great, have a go at it. If not, your lack of innovation isn’t your biggest problem.”

This thinking highlights an important principle of exnovation. For a multinational company with a presence in different geographies, you often face region-wise challenges. These challenges result from apparent differences in consumer behaviours compared to the parent market of the company. So, how do you manage such matters?

In my experience, a set process and structure of innovation and strategy are important. Additionally, specialised teams with vested authority make a good fit here. They can study the local market’s needs and see how they could be fulfilled within the existing system. Then, if any changes are to be made, they can tailor the existing process, products, or system. I wrote about these special-purpose teams in a previous article in this series.

Special-purpose teams play a crucial role in innovation as well as exnovation.

During my tenure with LG Electronics in India, each LG factory had its own R&D and TDR (special-purpose tear down re-engineering) teams. So, we would work on joining and separating innovative projects all the time. But when it came to feedback from the local market and

adapting the products, each team had a degree of freedom to work on it for making necessary changes that suited the local market and implemented them at scale. And for those improvements that were nationally or globally applied, the company made sure that these improvements got adopted by all.

The point is, if changes in established design and processes are to be made to suit geographic needs, teams

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need to be empowered to experiment with those changes first. Then, once validated, there must be a process to recommend them to other units and have them formally introduced or regularised for all, when applicable. Once done, it becomes a standard process again, which need not be tampered with any further.

Important piece in innovation puzzle

Exnovation is not about saying no to innovation. It is about hammering out a process and structure to implement it at scale. Once established, everybody need not innovate but implement it to the ‘T’.

Counterintuitive but true. You can then put a team in charge that will check processes and structures throughout the organisation and improve them when the need arises. Exnovation means the opposite of innovation only to an extent. Mainly, it is about keeping a check on the in-

novation process in your company.

Once a process, product, or system is evaluated, validated, and almost mastered by the special-purpose team in the organisation, the next step is to put in place a critical system. A system that will ensure this new change is replicated across branches, departments, units, factories, or similar groups within your organisation.

Ensuring the process is implemented without any alteration is highly important. No one within the organisation should be allowed to tailor the process further for whatever reason.

Innovation can give an organisation the much-needed big leap, but only if favourable processes and systems are passed on and repeated seamlessly by all involved. A strict check on customisation by anyone at random must be kept. Let the special-purpose teams take that call. Give them the liberty and latitude to manage it.

The point is

In defense, not everyone is a commanding officer. In orchestra, not everyone is a conductor. In an organisation, not everyone can be an innovator.

If you want to be an innovative company, you cannot be one without the process and structure around it. Whether it is around innovation activity or the downstream delivery mechanism to deliver it, innovation and process within a company must coexist and feed off each other.

Innovation, in its true sense, includes creating culture and systems that help in effectively sustaining innovation. Your people and innovation teams are central to promoting internal and external collaboration. However, for innovation to be really nurtured, you need to establish a solid process with clear communication and appropriate employee training.

It is not just the effort that we put into innovation that decides success. It is how we go about innovating, its structure and its process. **EFY**